

9.4 Design Thinking Framework

Design thinking is a human-centered, iterative problem-solving approach that focuses on understanding user needs, generating creative solutions, and continuously refining ideas through prototyping and testing. It is widely used in entrepreneurship, product development, and service innovation to create impactful, user-friendly solutions. The process consists of five key phases: **Empathize, Define, Ideate, Prototype, and Test**—with iteration as a crucial component.

Here's how design thinking can be applied to decision-making in entrepreneurship, along with some key steps.

Empathize – Understanding User Needs

The first step in design thinking is developing a deep understanding of users' experiences, motivations, and challenges. This involves engaging directly with users through interviews, observations, and research. By stepping into their shoes, businesses can uncover pain points that might not be immediately obvious. Rather than assuming what users want, this phase relies on real-world insights to identify their actual needs, frustrations, and aspirations.



Define – Framing the Problem

Once user insights are gathered, the next step is to clearly articulate the problem that needs solving. This phase involves synthesizing findings and pinpointing the root cause of the issue. A well-defined problem statement should be specific, user-focused, and solution-oriented. One of the most effective ways to frame this is by using "How Might We" (HMW) questions, which open the door to creative problem-solving. A precise definition ensures that the next phases remain focused on solving the right problem rather than just addressing surface-level symptoms.



Ideate – Generating Creative Solutions

Ideation is where teams explore multiple possible solutions by thinking expansively and challenging assumptions. Instead of settling for the first idea, the goal is to generate a diverse range of solutions that push creative boundaries. Techniques like mind mapping, SCAMPER (Substitute, Combine, Adapt, Modify, Put to another use, Eliminate, Reverse), and storyboarding help in unlocking new perspectives. This phase embraces a fail-fast, learn-fast mentality, encouraging risk-taking and unconventional thinking before narrowing down to the most viable ideas.